

Egyptian pyramids

The pyramids were built as tombs for the rulers of Egypt's Old and Middle Kingdoms between c.2600 and 1800 BCE. Three types were built: step, bent and straight-sided. The most imposing are those at Giza (opposite), the largest of which was built for the pharaoh Khufu.

The pyramid shape is believed to have been favoured for the great heights that could be achieved, the notion of pointing directly up to the gods, and the commanding presence they created across the surrounding flat valleys. In a practical sense, fewer stones were required to be hauled to the top. These massive constructions – some rise up to 146 metres (450ft) while some of the blocks of limestone weigh 15 tonnes – were built with the utmost precision; the casing stones are so finely joined that a knife's edge cannot fit between them. Within, narrow passages lead to the royal burial chambers. Gypsum mortar held the blocks together, and the entire structures were encased in smooth white limestone quarried from the east bank of the River Nile, with the summit often topped in gold.

